

Experimental if you can help it. Experimental packages are dangerous to the point where they can cause massive data loss. However, some packages such as LibreOffice (suddenly everyone's obsession) are currently (as of this writing) in Experimental only, so there's only one way of getting such packages.

Experimental is implemented in a fashion that's similar to Backports, but with additional safeguards—you have to manually update packages from Experimental; even updates will not be delivered automatically.

So how do you add these two repos? Well, start by creating an empty file in `/etc/apt/sources.list.d` (you can create one file for each repo, or put both repos in a single file). By the way, in Squeeze, Apt now supports splitting your `sources.list` file into many parts stored in the `sources.list.d` directory. The `sources.list` file still exists, though, and is also parsed, right at the beginning.

For Experimental, fill in the following code:

```
deb http://ftp.debian.org/debian experimental main
deb-src http://ftp.debian.org/debian experimental main
```

For Backports, use the commands given below:

```
deb http://backports.debian.org/debian-backports squeeze-
backports main
deb-src http://backports.debian.org/debian-backports squeeze-
backports main
```

Now update your package metadata by running `apt-get update`, and install packages by targeting the release, such as `apt-get -t experimental install packagename`, or `apt-get -t squeeze-backports install packagename`.

If you want to automatically track updates from Experimental, you'll have to do it package by package, using a technique known as Apt-pinning. Edit the `/etc/apt/preferences` file, and add the following for every package you want to track:

```
Package: packagename
Pin: release a=experimental
Pin-Priority: 800
```

This isn't necessary for Backports, since once you install a package from there, updates are automatically tracked.

The verdict

Debian 6 was in many ways an important and path-breaking release of Debian, but is it really relevant today? Debian as a desktop system isn't really something you'd like to use—it's too old. Debian for servers? Well, it does the job extremely well, but Ubuntu Server, while providing LTS releases every two years (which coincides with Debian's new release cycle), has better support from applications, built-in support for EC2 clouds, and commercial support from Canonical (with stuff like Landscape, which even Red Hat cannot boast of).

Moreover, day by day, Debian is getting more purist in its approach. For a server OS, it beats me why SELinux or AppArmor wasn't included, and the fact remains that even if I use it as a desktop, it still needs a bit of tinkering around with configuration files in `/etc` to fully realise the potential of the system. Although I do agree that porting in Software Center from Ubuntu was a very nice touch, and it does make managing repositories and installing software a lot easier.

There's only one thing I can say about Debian 6: it may have been released just yesterday, but it got outdated 6 months ago. So unless you have a reason for using Debian, both on the server and desktop front, I'd recommend Ubuntu. On the other hand, if you do have that reason for using Debian, go ahead and upgrade, because you will be blown away by the amount of polish that has gone into this release. Debian 6 is indeed a worthy upgrade to Debian 5, but not really to other distros.  **END**

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Boudhayan Gupta likes to describe himself as a complete 'retard by choice'. He believes madness is the cure for everything that is wrong—or right—with society. He's also a social media enthusiast, and can be reached at @BaloneyGeek over at Twitter.

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